had defected to the BJP. The seat has now been annexed by the ruling BRS—an ominous sign for the Congress that has been reduced to an also-ran with the 2023 poll increasingly becoming a race between the BRS, steered by Chief Minister K. Chandrashekar Rao, and the BJP, which is rapidly growing in influence in the state.

After 12 of the 18 MLAs elected on the Congress ticket in 2018 switched to the ruling party in 2019 (when N. Uttam Kumar Reddy was the TPCC chief), the party has been losing influential leaders steadily to the BJP and BRS. Among them are M. Shashidhar Reddy, son of former Andhra Pradesh CM M. Channa Reddy who had steered the first separate statehood agitation in the 1970s, former MP K. Vishweshwar Reddy, former MLA Challa Venkatrami Reddy and former AICC spokesperson Dasoju Sravan Kumar. More heavyweights are expected to drift from the Congress towards the saffron party, which is banking on anti-incumbency and focusing on about 75 of the 119 assembly seats to dislodge the two-term BRS government.

WITH LESS THAN A YEAR TO GO FOR ASSEMBLY ELECTION, THE CONGRESS FINDS ITSELF IN DISARRAY IN TELANGANA

So, is it the end of the road for the Congress in Telangana? "The primary crisis springs from the deep lack of morale in the leadership to stand its ground. Since the formation of Telangana, the traditional Reddy leadership has been content with the way the ruling BRS is treating them which has, in turn, compromised their fighting capabilities," explains Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad.

Further, Revanth Reddy's entry had been a long-drawn process after the non-Reddy Congress elite, comprising BCs, SCs and STs, yielded space instead of taking the party's reins, as Siddaramaiah did in Karnataka. As a consequence, sections of Dalits and Muslims have drifted away from the Congress in Telangana. "The Congress may have to shed some of its troublesome deadweight, the so-called senior leaders, considering it still has a good base in the state as was evident during Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra," says Vageeshan. He believes that with such an excision, a new balance can be struck in the party in the coming months.

Meanwhile, with the reactivation of the TDP in Telangana, the Congress faces yet another challenge. Poll pundits argue that the BJP, with Sharmila Reddy's fledgling YSR Telangana Party and possibly the TDP, has the potential to poach from the Congress vote bank. "The current crisis will only weaken the electoral prospects of the Congress further," says E. Venkatesu of the political science department, University of Hyderabad. Facing a grim future in what was once its bastion, the Congress will have to keep its house in order if it wants to put up any sort of challenge in 2023. ■



By Pradip R. Sagar

In September 1999, a Japanese-owned, Panama-registered ship, the *MV Alondra Rainbow*, was hijacked by Indonesian pirates. The ship was repainted and renamed *MV Mega Rama* by the pirates. Within days, it was apprehended by the Indian Coast Guard off the Mumbai coast in the Arabian Sea. It was India's first case dealing with pirates. The Mumbai sessions court tried and convicted the pirates under various sections of the Indian Penal Code (IPC). However, on April 18, 2005, the Bombay High Court overruled the lower court's decision and acquitted all the accused. The reason: the IPC and Criminal Procedure Code (CrPC) were invalid beyond Indian territorial waters, which stretches up to 12 nautical miles from any Indian coastal state. That legal gap has now been filled. To deal with the menace of piracy on the high seas, both houses of Parliament last week passed the Maritime Anti-Piracy Bill 2022, which provides for the prevention of maritime piracy and stringent punishment to those convicted of such crimes. Despite a sharp rise in piracy, there had been no legislation in India specifically dealing with the crime.

The 'Piracy Bill' was first tabled in April 2012 by the then external affairs minister, S.M. Krishna. The Narendra Modi-led government reintroduced the bill as the Maritime Anti-Piracy Bill in the Lok Sabha on